

The long apprenticeship of Kartik Sharma

On winter mornings in Jaipur, long before the noise of stadiums and auctions, Kartik kept returning to the nets, **rehearsing a future** that was not yet guaranteed.

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That morning, the Aravali Cricket Club on the outskirts of Jaipur sat inside a fog thick enough to blur faces at arm's length.

It was around nine o'clock. With visibility close to zero, the academy students stacked their kit bags in one corner and waited it out, sipping warm beverages or slurping piping-hot instant noodles. Extreme weather conditions meant their regular training routine had gone for a toss. As the young cricketers

engaged in conversation and banter, a car pulled up near the academy entrance.

The change was immediate.

Moments earlier, the youngsters had been joking around. Now, they rushed towards the ground, some scrambling to tie their shoelaces as they went. "*Chalo, chalo, Kartik bhaiya aa gayein hain...* (Let's get going, brother Kartik is here)," shouted one of the boys, as his friends gulped down the last of their noodles and jogged out to stretch.

Within minutes, the academy premises came alive. Kartik *bhaiya* parked his car at one end of the ground, slung a small backpack over his shoulder, and slipped into his routine, training under

the watchful eye of his trainer, Vijay Golada.

That is how most mornings unfold for Kartik Sharma.

Ever since he was picked by the Chennai Super Kings (CSK) at the Indian Premier League (IPL) auction for Rs 14.2 crore, Kartik's life has changed. Or so one would think. The shy 19-year-old refuses to see it that way. "I'm still the same," he says with a smile, pausing briefly between sets of push-ups.

A finger injury forced him to miss the Super League stage of the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy and the Vijay Hazare Trophy. Though he has resumed training, there is still no clarity on whether he will be fit in time for Rajasthan's final two Ranji Trophy fixtures.

For now, Kartik's focus lies elsewhere: making the most of his opportunity at CSK.

Breaking straight into the playing eleven will not be easy, particularly

EMMANUEL YOGINI

